DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Does the World Exist Only by God's Will?

Daat Tevunot §57-58

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §57-58 (with a review of §56; §58 is begun and continued after the break) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 15 December 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review of §56: the hidden line within good and bad

The Rabbi set the aim of the evening: to finish this part of the book before the Hanukkah break, so that the group could revise. He began by reading §56 again.

God's perfection itself can never be grasped. To act with us at our level, He set up a system through which the whole world comes to its perfection, and this system is what is hidden within everything. A small part of it will be revealed when He opens our eyes; most of it will stay concealed.

The Ramhal adds a distinction. What comes directly from God is His perfection. The imperfections and the bad in the world are related to Him only indirectly: they follow, as if automatically, from His holding back His light, which leaves something like a vacuum. Yet even within that vacuum there is a line of light running through the good and the bad, bringing everything towards perfection. In the end, when all is revealed, everything will be traced back to Him directly.

§57: the whole system exists only by God's will

The final point of the section: the entire system the Ramhal has described, justice, good and bad, the concealment and the revelation of God's unity, exists only because God wills it at every moment. If He did not will it, it would cease to exist. The Ramhal writes that He rules completely and without limit, "for He said and it was, He commanded and it stood", and that His might is recognised in the fact that He alone sustains every detail.

The Rabbi recalled an analogy he has given before. Close your eyes and dream up a world for half a minute, with whatever islands and people you like. Then someone tells you there is a phone call, your attention is diverted, and the world is gone. It existed only while you were willing it. That is true of the universe, and the new point here is that it is also true of the way the universe is run.

A participant asked what the practical difference is between God creating the world and letting it run until He decides otherwise, and God sustaining it every moment. The Rabbi rejected the first picture firmly. It is not like something I make and put to the side of my mind

until I choose to delete it. "The fact that you exist, the fact that I exist, is because we are being sustained by that force every moment."

§58: "He is the place of the world"

The Rabbi called §58 deeper. The Ramhal cites the saying of Hazal in the Midrash: "He is the place of the world, and the world is not His place."

We often imagine a world, and God inside it, here and there and everywhere. The Rabbi said that is not correct. God is not in the world; the world is in Him. As with the world you imagine in your head, you are not somewhere inside it; it exists only within you. Asked whether children are then taught wrongly, he answered that they are not: children have to be taught in simple terms, and one deepens the understanding with maturity.

From here the Ramhal draws out a principle of faith. Nothing in creation is a necessary existence. "I exist, you exist, but we don't have to exist." Since nothing has to exist, whatever does exist exists only because God wills it, and therefore He must will it continuously. This is how the Rabbi read the verses and sayings about the waters standing by God's word, and the image that God carries the world "from underneath": He is not standing in the world but holding it up.

Against the eternity of the world

The Ramhal concludes that God must therefore be first, the primal cause. The Rabbi explained that the Ramhal is arguing here against the view of Aristotle that the world is eternal: that God and the world always existed side by side, with no creation from nothing. That is wrong. Even if you had been holding your imagined world in mind for a year, it would still exist only because you will it, and you would still come before it. If anything, the Rabbi added, the natural state is that we should not exist at all: only God is necessary, and He had to make room for us. The universe exists only because He decided that it should.

Questions

Could God end it all? A participant asked whether, since the world exists for humanity to reach olam haba, God might simply stop willing it. The Rabbi said that within this universe there is a plan, a past and a future, and it makes sense that it will continue. God could stop it, as a dreamer can choose to stop dreaming. Will He? "If I could answer that question I would be God himself." He agreed that the probability is overwhelmingly that He will not.

Which vacuum? Another asked whether the vacuum is needed to allow existence or to allow evil. The Rabbi agreed that even to create perfect beings God would need to withdraw, and that a further withdrawal is needed for good and bad and free choice.

Is God within time? A third asked why we speak of God as "before" and "after". The Rabbi said this is not a matter of translation but of the human mind: we live in past, present and future and cannot think otherwise. God is beyond time, as in the story of Moshe being shown Rabbi Akiva. The same limitation underlies the problem of God's foreknowledge and our free will, which is a real problem only for a mind that lives within time.

Homework for the break

The next paragraph, the Rabbi said, is a topic of its own and should not be rushed. Because of Hanukkah there would be a two week break. He asked everyone who is serious about the book to read the English summaries of the first three sections (page 20, pages 82-86, and pages 136-140), and warned that there would be questions when they came back. "These are the foundations now. You have to know these foundations, otherwise it's not going to flow."

Summary

- §56: the bad comes from God only indirectly, through His withholding His light, yet a line of light runs through it towards perfection.
- §57: not only the world but the entire system by which it is run exists only because God wills it at every moment.
- §58: "He is the place of the world, and the world is not His place": the world exists within God, not God within the world.
- Nothing is a necessary existence except God, which refutes the view that the world is eternal.
- The class closed with a two week break and an assignment to revise the summaries of sections 1-3.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/s4enrPARh-4 · More shiurim: rabbikada.com